

age of three friends is one of the first films to be considered an urban or a multiplex hit. "It's a very cool and truly phenomenal film. It got many people to replicate that urban success. As multiplex penetration grew in urban India, film-making sensibilities changed," says Rathi. Film-makers in the North began catering to the NRI and metro audiences. The glitz and pomp of multiplexes meant that tickets were priced at 3x of single-screen rates. The logic was that one multiplex viewer equals three single-screen viewers.

As it is, India is under-screened with about 8,000 movie screens compared to China's 80,000. Dhishoom Cinemas' CEO Tushar Dhingra estimates that 5,000 of the 5,564 sub-districts in the country don't have a cinema theatre. "That's one structural gap we have as a country that needs to be filled," he says. The South alone accounts for nearly half the country's screens, with its propensity for single-screens mostly intact. Says Rajamouli: "In Telugu, Tamil or Kannada, we kept on making films catering to single-screen audiences as well because we're making films only for one state and we have to get all the audiences to the theatre."

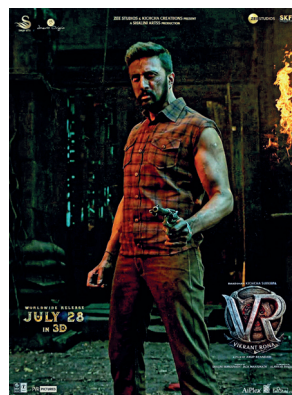
On the other hand, Rathi says, Bollywood ignored 75 per cent of the population with multiplex content and ticket pricing. They forgot that urban audiences have many avenues for recreation, but the choice for smaller cities is usually between watching a movie and eating out. "That has become the undoing of the Hindi film industry in some sense, where a bulk of the population looking for escapist viewing has been alienated. They found their entertainment in SET Max and Star Gold through Allu Arjun, Junior NTR and Ram Charan."

Delhi-based distributor and Proprietor of Bobby Enterprises, Sanjay Mehta, picks *Pushpa* and *KGF2* particularly as saviours for single-screen theatres in the Delhi-UP belt. "When the Omicron restrictions stopped the flow of Hindi films again, *Pushpa* saw exhibitors sail through a tough time." "Initially, I had seven shows of 83 and two to three shows of *Pushpa*. Within three to four days, it was the other way around. This was the general trend in other theatres, too," says Pratapgarh-based Pavan Agarwal, who owns DD Cinemas, a chain of 20 cinema screens in 11 UP districts. To cash in on the extraordinary demand for *KGF2*, he raised his ticket rates from ₹150 and ₹200 to ₹200 and ₹250, without seeing any decline in footfalls. Sounding like a true showbiz man, he says: "*Shauk ki keemat nahi hoti!*" Translated, that would be "Passion is priceless!"

Says Applause Entertainment CEO Sameer Nair: "We used to play *Indra: The Tiger* (Hindi dub of Telugu film *Indra*) and our ratings were sorted for two weeks." Telugu films and their stars—be they Chiranjeevi, Nagarjuna, Mahesh Babu or Allu Arjun—gradually cultivated a big fan base among Hindi-speaking

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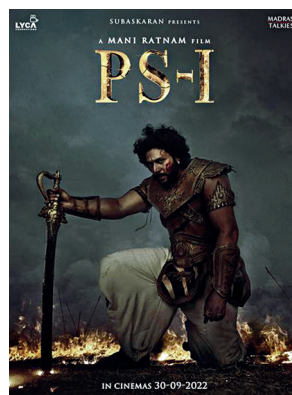


FILM LIGER

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